

CHAPTER 4 — Cain

The service area looked tired enough to have survived several governments.

Its petrol station occupied one side of the slip road beneath a canopy stained by years of exhaust. The main building stood opposite, low and broad, with three shopfronts shuttered behind metal grilles. Portable toilets had been placed near the coach park as though the permanent ones had lost an argument.

One restaurant remained open.

THE YE OLD BARN

Its illuminated sign promised food, warmth and several varieties of pie.

The dark saloon entered the service area thirty seconds behind them.

Elias watched it in the rear-view mirror.

It did not follow the hatchback towards the restaurant.

It continued past the fuel pumps, crossed the car park and disappeared behind a line of coaches.

Not gone.

Only repositioned.

Zoe watched the mirror too.

Neither mentioned it.

Elias drove once around the main car park before choosing a space beneath two cameras and within sight of the restaurant windows. A delivery van occupied the bay on one side. A family car sat on the other, its rear doors open while two children argued over a football.

Public.

Visible.

Several exits, none ideal.

He switched off the engine.

Zoe did not release her seat belt.

Her face had regained some colour after the water, but she remained too pale. Her eyes closed once and opened immediately, as if sleep had approached without permission.

"We're eating," Elias said.

"I told you I'm not hungry."

"You told me you don't want food."

"Same thing."

"No."

She looked towards the restaurant.

Then the coach park.

Then the fuel station.

The backpack remained upright against her chest.

"What if that car was following us?"

"It was."

Zoe turned towards him.

"You said maybe."

"I had less evidence then."

"And now?"

"It left the motorway when we did, ignored fuel, ignored the main exit and moved out of direct sight."

"That could still be nothing."

"Yes."

"You sound certain."

"I'm certain enough to change how we stop. Not certain enough to decide who they are."

She examined the car park through the rear window.

"Then why go inside?"

"Cameras. Staff. Witnesses. Two public exits and a kitchen delivery door."

"You checked that from here?"

"The building plan is painted beside the fire assembly sign. I read it when we passed the entrance."

Zoe looked towards the wall near the restaurant entrance.

A faded diagram showed the public doors, kitchen access and external meeting point.

"While you were driving?"

"Yes."

"That's irritating."

"It improves with familiarity."

Her eyes returned to the coach park.

"What if they're waiting outside when we leave?"

"Then we don't leave the way they expect."

"That isn't a plan."

"It is the part of one you need before lunch."

She looked at him.

"No calls while we're inside."

"I may need to call Mac."

"Then tell me first."

Elias considered the request.

The withheld number had already called three times. Whoever had used it might not have been Mac. The distinction mattered more now.

"Fine."

"And the phone stays where I can see it."

"Fine."

"And I sit where I can see the door."

"I was planning to."

"That doesn't mean I was."

Elias opened his door.

Zoe remained seated.

He waited.

She tested her own handle before climbing out.

* * *

Wind moved across the service area carrying diesel fumes, fried food and the sour chemical smell from the portable toilets.

The two children beside the family car had abandoned the football argument and begun kicking it against the rear tyre. Their mother stood between them and the building, holding three drinks and asking nobody in particular why every journey became an expedition.

A coach driver smoked beside the luggage compartment of a vehicle marked for a seaside town.

Two lorry drivers stood near the entrance comparing traffic delays with the seriousness of medical diagnoses.

Ordinary people occupied the space.

That helped.

It also provided cover for anyone patient enough to appear ordinary.

Elias walked ahead.

Zoe followed on his left, close enough that he could see her reflection in the restaurant glass.

She did not look towards the coaches.

Neither did he.

The automatic doors opened.

Warm air touched them first.

Then the smell.

Fried oil.

Old timber.

Gravy.

The entrance led through a small shop selling bottled drinks, travel sweets and local souvenirs manufactured somewhere that had probably never seen the local area. Beyond it, the restaurant occupied one long room with dark beams across the ceiling and windows facing the car park.

A server in a green apron approached with two laminated menus.

“Table for two?”

Elias looked towards Zoe rather than answering for her.

She noticed.

"Yes," she said.

"Window or booth?"

"Booth," Elias replied.

Zoe said, "Window."

The server looked between them.

Elias asked, "Why?"

"I want to see outside."

"A person outside can see you too."

"The booth has one way out."

"It also has a mirrored panel behind the counter."

Zoe glanced towards it.

The panel reflected the entrance, half the car park and the corridor leading towards the toilets.

"Booth," she said.

The server led them towards the rear.

Elias allowed Zoe to enter first so she could choose the side.

She selected the seat facing the entrance.

He sat opposite with the window reflection over her shoulder.

The backpack remained beside her on the bench rather than beneath the table. One strap stayed looped around her wrist.

The server placed the menus down.

"Kitchen closes the hot counter in forty minutes. Pies and grills until then."

Zoe opened the menu.

Her expression changed.

Not fear.

Disappointment.

"Spit it out," Elias said.

"I'm vegetarian."

"Of course you are."

"What does that mean?"

"It means the universe has arranged for the only open restaurant to specialise in dead animals."

The corner of her mouth moved.

She stopped it before it became a smile.

The menu offered steak pie, chicken pie, meat-and-potato pie, burgers, roast dinners and a salad described as garden fresh beside a photograph that suggested the garden had been abandoned.

"There are chips," Elias said.

"Cooked in what?"

He looked at the server.

"Vegetable oil," she said. "Separate fryer since January."

"Since January?" Zoe asked.

"The manager's daughter stopped eating meat."

"Is the salad actually food?"

The server considered the photograph.

"It has improved."

"That isn't yes."

"I'd choose the baked potato."

Zoe studied the menu.

"What comes with it?"

"Beans, cheese or salad."

"No butter?"

"We can leave it off."

"No animal fat on the tray?"

The server did not laugh or become impatient.

"No animal fat."

"Baked potato. Beans."

"Drink?"

"Water."

"Bottle or tap?"

Zoe looked at Elias.

"Bottle," he said.

"Sealed," Zoe added.

The server wrote it down without comment.

Elias ordered steak pie, chips and tea.

Zoe looked at him.

"You said we were eating."

"I am."

"That doesn't look healthy."

“Neither do I. Consistency matters.”

The server collected the menus.

For a few seconds, Zoe watched her cross the room.

“You let me order.”

“That is generally how restaurants work.”

“You didn’t choose.”

“You are vegetarian. I am not qualified to select your apology salad.”

She looked towards the mirrored panel.

The front entrance opened.

An elderly couple entered carrying matching waterproof jackets. Behind them, a man in a grey sweatshirt walked towards the shop and stopped at the newspaper rack.

Not one of the two occupants Elias had briefly seen in the saloon.

Possibly no connection.

He catalogued him anyway.

Zoe noticed Elias’s attention shift.

“What?”

“Nothing yet.”

“That means something.”

“It means nothing has become useful.”

She looked towards the entrance.

“Don’t.”

The word came quietly.

Zoe’s head stopped before turning fully.

"Watch the mirror," Elias said.

"You said this wasn't a lesson."

"It isn't."

"What is it?"

"Less obvious staring."

She looked at the reflective panel instead.

The man at the newspaper rack selected a paper, turned it over and returned it without reading the front page.

He left the shop.

Zoe's hand tightened around the backpack strap.

"That was him?"

"I don't know."

"You saw him."

"I saw a man fail to buy a newspaper."

"That sounds suspicious when you say it."

"Most things do."

The server returned with two sealed bottles of water and Elias's tea.

Zoe checked the cap before opening hers.

Elias poured tea.

His hand remained steady.

The pain beneath his ribs had reduced since the saloon appeared.

Not improved.

Displaced.

The body could be useful that way. Present it with an external threat and it postponed its internal complaints.

Zoe drank.

Her eyelids lowered once.

The bottle touched the table harder than she intended.

"You're falling asleep," Elias said.

"I'm not."

"You just lost an argument with your own eyes."

"I was blinking."

"For three seconds."

She looked towards the window.

The coach park remained partially visible in the reflection. No dark saloon.

Elias asked, "How much did you sleep on the flight?"

"Enough."

"That is not a time."

"You agreed not to ask about the journey."

"I agreed not to interrogate you in Arrivals."

"You keep moving the border."

"You keep nearly collapsing."

"I'm sitting."

"Temporarily."

Zoe rubbed one thumb against the label on the bottle.

"I slept a little."

“How little?”

She did not answer.

Elias let the question go.

The food arrived.

The steak pie came beneath a layer of gravy thick enough to conceal structural damage. Zoe’s potato had been split and filled with beans. A wrapped packet of butter sat on the edge of the plate.

She looked at it.

The server saw.

“Sorry.”

She removed it immediately and replaced the plate rather than merely taking the packet away.

Zoe watched her carry the first one back towards the kitchen.

Elias said nothing.

The replacement arrived two minutes later on a clean tray.

“Thank you,” Zoe said.

It was the first uncomplicated politeness he had heard from her.

The server smiled and left.

Zoe used the fork to test the potato.

Steam escaped.

She took one small bite, then another.

Her body wanted food.

Her attention did not want to release the room long enough to eat it.

She chewed while watching the mirror.

The entrance.

The corridor.

The windows.

Elias cut into the pie.

"You can look at the plate."

"I know where it is."

"You have put the fork beside the food three times."

"I'm not hungry."

"You're eating."

"That doesn't mean I want to."

Elias looked at the beans.

For the first time, he noticed how carefully she avoided allowing the fork to scrape against the ceramic.

No unnecessary sound.

No sudden movement.

No request that might bring the server back.

A child trying to occupy as little attention as possible while monitoring every person in the room.

He looked away before the observation became visible.

"You don't look like someone Mac would send," Zoe said.

"What does someone Mac would send look like?"

"Cleaner."

Elias glanced at the gravy spot on his shirt.

"I iron my shirts."

"Not that one."

"Sometimes."

The corner of her mouth moved again.

This time she did not stop it quickly enough.

A brief smile appeared and disappeared.

It changed her age.

For one second, she looked thirteen rather than like somebody performing adulthood under threat.

Elias returned to the pie.

"Who taught you to start cars?"

The smile vanished.

"No one."

"That ignition gave you help, but not that much."

"You said no questions."

"You agreed to eat. We are both experiencing disappointment."

Zoe pushed a bean around the edge of the potato.

"Someone showed me once."

"Who?"

"No."

Elias nodded.

The refusal was an answer about the boundary, not the event.

He did not cross it.

"Were you supposed to use it today?"

"No."

"Then why did you?"

She looked at the mirrored panel.

The elderly couple had sat beside the window. One cut a pie in half and exchanged plates with the other without discussion.

The ordinary intimacy held Zoe's attention for a moment.

Then she said, "Because I thought the route was compromised."

Elias set down his fork.

"Before we left the airport."

"Yes."

"What told you?"

"The flight."

"That is transport, not a warning."

"It was both."

She took another bite.

The fork shook slightly before reaching her mouth.

Elias waited.

Zoe swallowed.

"They could have stopped me before I got on."

"Who?"

She looked at him.

"You don't know them."

"I know someone followed us."

"That doesn't mean you know anything."

"No."

He leaned back enough to see the entrance in the window reflection.

"You arrived without luggage. You checked whether I matched the photograph. You checked the boot, the child lock and the ignition. Somebody knew your flight. If they wanted to stop you leaving, the departure airport was easier."

Zoe's fork stopped.

"They weren't supposed to know the flight."

There it was.

Not disclosure.

A fracture in containment.

Elias kept his voice level.

"But they did."

She looked towards the bottle.

"You don't know that."

"The saloon joined behind us before the services."

"It could have followed from the motorway."

"Yes."

"Then it might have nothing to do with the flight."

"Yes."

"You agree too much."

"Accuracy is irritating."

Her fingers tightened around the fork.

Elias said, "If they knew the flight, why let you board?"

The question changed her breathing.

Not faster.

Shallower.

She had already asked herself.

More than once.

"Because the plane did the work for them," she said.

The answer came too quickly to be new.

Elias said nothing.

Zoe looked at the potato rather than him.

"It took me away from everyone who could help. One exit at the other end. One person collecting me. One route already entered into a phone."

Elias felt the old pressure beneath his ribs become cold.

Not pain.

Recognition.

Isolation disguised as travel.

A child converted into a handover between adults who each possessed only enough information to perform one stage.

"There was another route," he said.

Zoe's eyes lifted.

"A decoy."

Her hand closed around the fork until the knuckles lightened.

"Someone gave it away."

“Who knew the real one?”

She looked towards the mirror.

The hurt reached her face before discipline removed it.

Elias had seen the expression before.

Betrayal was easiest to recognise on people still searching for an alternative explanation.

He did not ask again.

Instead, he said, “They isolated you from the decoy and everyone behind it. The person at the airport delivered you to me without giving me a name, a number or a handover.”

Zoe’s eyes sharpened.

“You saw her.”

“Yes.”

“She wasn’t with me.”

“She walked beside you.”

“That isn’t the same.”

“No.”

The server approached with a jug of water.

Zoe stopped speaking.

“Everything all right?” the woman asked.

Elias looked at Zoe.

She nodded.

The server topped up Elias’s glass, collected an empty plate from the next table and moved away.

Zoe waited until she reached the counter.

"You keep looking at me when adults ask questions."

"You prefer answering for yourself."

"That doesn't mean they believe me."

"No."

"Do you?"

Elias looked at her.

The question was larger than the amount she had told him.

"I believe you think the route was exposed."

"That isn't the same."

"No."

"I believe someone followed us from the airport."

"That isn't the same either."

"No."

Zoe looked down.

He continued.

"I believe you had a reason to run from the destination before you knew whether I was dangerous."

Her eyes returned to him.

"That is what I can prove from your behaviour."

"Trust needs proof?"

"Yes."

"Then it isn't trust."

"It is the only kind worth having."

The answer remained between them.

Not warmth.

Structure.

Something Zoe could test later.

Elias cut another piece of pie.

"You ran with a rough crowd," he said.

"They weren't my crowd."

"No. They rarely are."

"You don't know them."

"Not personally."

The words altered the air around the table.

Zoe heard it.

"Then how do you know?"

Elias watched the mirrored entrance.

The man in the grey sweatshirt had not returned.

Two new customers entered: a woman with a sleeping toddler and a man carrying a motorcycle helmet.

Normal.

Then a tall figure crossed the far edge of the car park beyond the window.

Black jacket despite the warm afternoon.

Too far to identify.

Close enough to wake an old name inside Elias's memory.

He did not move.

"But I know what Cain does to people who think they can leave," he said.

Zoe whispered the name at almost the same moment.

"Cain."

Everything in Elias became still.

The fork stopped above the plate.

The ache in his ribs disappeared from attention.

His shoulders settled rather than tightened. His breathing reduced. The tired driver who had argued about parking charges and vegetarian food withdrew behind something colder and more exact.

Zoe saw it happen.

Her own composure fractured for less than a second.

Not because Elias knew a criminal name.

Because the name had changed him.

"How do you know Cain?"

"I've crossed paths with some of his people."

"And you're still alive?"

Elias lowered the fork.

"That sounds personal."

"It isn't."

"That wasn't an answer."

"No."

Zoe looked towards the mirror.

"Does Mac know him?"

Elias considered the question.

Mac knew too many people without appearing to know anyone.

"I don't know."

"You work for him."

"I drive for him."

"That's what people say when they want responsibility to stop at the steering wheel."

The sentence reached closer than Zoe knew.

Elias folded the napkin once.

"You've known me for an hour."

"Patterns don't need years."

The phone vibrated against the table.

No ringtone.

No name.

PRIVATE NUMBER

Zoe's eyes dropped to the screen.

Elias rejected the call.

The restaurant continued around them.

A child near the counter asked for ketchup.

The coffee machine released steam.

The man with the motorcycle helmet laughed at something on his phone.

The private number called again before the display went dark.

Elias rejected it a second time.

Zoe stopped eating.

The third call arrived immediately.

Not persistence.

Confirmation that the caller could see his response or predict it closely enough to create the same effect.

A cold prickle moved across the back of Elias's neck.

He answered.

"Who is this?"

A man's voice spoke without introduction.

"Send the girl outside and you can leave alive."

The line went dead.

Elias kept the phone against his ear for one second longer.

Not because he expected more.

Because moving too quickly would tell Zoe the call had changed the room.

He placed it face down.

"What did they say?" she asked.

He looked into the window reflection.

Two men stood beneath the shade of the entrance awning.

Neither faced the restaurant directly.

One watched the car park.

The other used the black glass beside the doors to observe the booths behind him.

They had not been there when the food arrived.

Beyond them, near the coach park, the dark saloon sat between two larger vehicles.

Driver inside.

Possibly another passenger.

The tall man in the black jacket was no longer visible.

Elias counted lines of approach.

Front doors.

Shop entrance joining the same lobby.

Kitchen exit.

Toilet corridor with a frosted external window too small to use.

Four visible.

More likely nearby.

"We were followed from the airport," he said.

Zoe went completely still.

"How many?"

Her voice remained controlled.

Her fingers did not.

They trembled around the fork.

"Two who want to be seen. One in the saloon. More may be out of sight."

"Cain's?"

"Yes."

The certainty came from the caller's words, not the men.

Zoe looked towards the entrance.

"Don't."

Her eyes returned to Elias.

"Watch the mirror."

She did.

The man nearest the awning shifted his weight.

Shoulders slightly forward.

Hands empty and visible.

A posture designed to appear non-aggressive while keeping every direction available.

Zoe recognised it.

"They're waiting."

"Yes."

"For me to run."

"Yes."

"Why not come inside?"

"Cameras. witnesses. uncertain resistance."

Her eyes moved to him in the mirror.

"You."

"Possibly."

"You said they don't know you."

"I said I don't know them personally."

The distinction frightened her more.

Elias slid cash beneath the edge of his plate.

"Listen carefully."

Zoe looked directly at him.

"You will go to the ladies' toilets. Stay there for three minutes."

"No."

It came immediately.

Elias kept his voice flat.

"You asked me to tell you before changing the plan. I'm telling you."

"You're separating us."

"I'm moving you out of their sightline while I count the exits."

"They can use the other door."

"There is no usable external door from the toilets."

"You checked?"

"Fire plan."

"What happens after three minutes?"

"You return to this table."

"And you?"

"I won't be here."

Her hand closed around the backpack strap.

"No."

"Zoe."

"You don't know the building."

"I know enough."

"You don't know how many there are."

"That is why I'm going outside."

"You said the restaurant is safer."

"For you."

The words struck the same structure she already distrusted.

An adult choosing where she remained while he controlled the information.

Elias saw it.

He adjusted the instruction.

"When you reach the corridor, look through the small window in the fire door. If anyone enters behind you, return to the dining room and go to the server. Do not enter the toilets with someone following."

Zoe listened despite herself.

"Lock the main door once inside. Stay for exactly three minutes. When you return, sit here. The cash covers the bill. Do not take the change. Do not leave the restaurant for anyone except me."

"What if someone says you sent them?"

"I won't."

"What if they know my name?"

"They do."

"What if you don't come back?"

Elias held her eyes.

The answer required honesty, not reassurance.

"Then the restaurant remains safer than the car park. You go to the server and tell her to call airport police, not the number in your travel documents."

Zoe's face changed at the final instruction.

He had remembered.

The folder at the airport would return her to the same system.

"Why airport police?"

"Because they can verify where you entered the country and who escorted you through. It creates a record Mac does not control completely."

"Completely."

"No system is clean."

She looked towards the entrance reflection.

One of the men moved closer to the doors.

Elias said, "Three minutes. Repeat it."

"Go to the corridor. Check the fire-door window. Lock the main toilet door. Stay three minutes. Come back here. Pay. Don't take the change. Don't leave."

"Who do you speak to if I don't return?"

"The server. Airport police."

"Who do you trust if they say I sent them?"

"No one."

"Good."

"That was praise."

"It was confirmation."

The old exchange did not belong to them yet.

The shape of it began here.

Zoe slid from the booth.

Her legs nearly failed when she stood.

She caught the table edge before the movement became visible to anyone else.

Elias did not reach for her.

She straightened, pulled the backpack onto both shoulders and walked towards the corridor at an ordinary pace.

At the entrance, the two men remained outside.

The server carried plates between tables.

A child complained that peas had touched his chips.

Nothing in the restaurant admitted that the threat had arrived.

Zoe reached the corridor.

She checked the fire-door window exactly as instructed.

Then she looked back once.

Elias's half-eaten pie remained on the table.

His tea steamed beside it.

The opposite seat was already empty.